GOA IS NOT CHOOSING BETWEEN THE BEACH AND THE TEMPLE. IT IS LEARNING TO GOVERN BOTH

As Goa's Tourism and Information Technology Minister, ROHAN A. KHAUNTE is overseeing the most ambitious reimagining of the state's tourism identity in a generation - from unregulated coastal excess to a mature, managed, year-round destination.



In an exclusive conversation with India Today, Minister for Tourism, Information Technology, Electronics & Communications and Printing & Stationery, Government of Goa. Rohan A. Khaunte presents a compelling case that quality tourism and inclusive tourism are not opposing ideas. They are the same idea, pursued with greater discipline.

The conversation around Goa tourism increasingly uses the word "quality." Does that mean budget travellers are no longer welcome?

Goa is not moving away from budget travellers. It is moving away from unregulated tourism. Quality cannot be measured by the size of a visitor's wallet. It is measured by responsible conduct, regulatory compliance, the depth of engagement, and the value retained in the local economy. In 2025, Goa welcomed 1.08 crore visitors, the state remains open and accessible to every category of traveller. What we are saying is that every tourism business, whether a five-star resort or a neighbourhood homestay, must meet safety, fire, hygiene, taxation, and guest-registration norms. Our message is simple: every traveller is welcome, but every tourism business must be accountable. Quality tourism, for us, is not exclusive tourism.

Some international destinations are significantly cheaper than Goa. How does the state stay competitive?

Goa offers something that no price comparison can capture the range. Within a compact geography, a visitor can experience beaches, rivers, forests, waterfalls, wildlife, temples, churches, heritage precincts, village festivals, wellness, adventure, and one of India's most distinctive culinary cultures. That breadth cannot be assessed through room rates alone. Our strategy is to strengthen a year-round calendar, improve destination infrastructure and mobility, deepen airline partnerships, and create experiences that give visitors more reasons to stay longer and return. Premium tourism does not have to mean expensive tourism. It means that every rupee and every day spent in Goa should feel genuinely worthwhile.

The Ekadasha Teertha Yatra is generating considerable interest. Does it signal that Goa's beaches have reached saturation point?

It signals the maturity of Goa's tourism offering, not the saturation of its beaches. Our beaches will remain a major attraction, but they are the gateway to Goa, not the entirety of Goa. The Ekadasha Teertha Yatra brings forward the state's civilisational depth: temple traditions, architecture, local legends, and living cultural practices. Today's traveller increasingly seeks meaning alongside leisure. Spiritual, cultural, and heritage experiences allow visitors to understand Goa more deeply and help distribute tourism beyond the coast. The circuit complements beach tourism. It does not compete with it.

How does the government reconcile Goa's reputation for nightlife and entertainment with

EKADASHA TEERTHA A SANCTUARY OF SPIRITUAL REFLECTION


BRAHMA TEMPLE-BRAMHAKARAMBALI, SATTARI


SHANTADURGA TEMPLE, FATORPA


HARI MANDIR, MARGAO


SHRI DAMODAR TEMPLE, ZAMBAULIM


PARASHURAM TEMPLE, POINGUINIM


SRI DEVKI KRISHNA TEMPLE, MARCEL


MAHAGANAPATI TEMPLE, KHANDOLA-PONDA


SAPTAKOYESHWAR TEMPLE, NARVE-GOA


DATTATREYA TEMPLE, SANKHALIM


SHRIMAD ANANT DEVASTHAN, SAVOI-VEREM


MAHADEV TEMPLE, TAMBDI SURLA